



PHOTOGRAPH: Mexy Xavier IMAGING: Atul Deshmukh

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Turn your PC into a fax and answering machine for your office

Sure, it seems really professional to have an answering machine for your company. That way you never miss another important call—the machine always gets it. Answering machines cost only Rs 3,000 to Rs 15,000. This is cheap for any decent sized company, but is that the only solution? Vehemently, we say, “No!” How about one that costs nothing? Yes, nothing. Sounds good? How about one that also doubles up as a Fax machine?

Most PCs already have a modem, internal or external. Most modems built after 2000 are Voice/Fax/Data capable. So all you probably need to do is find an existing computer in the office that has one of these modems connected. Even if you don't have one, you can buy an internal PCI Voice/Fax/Data modem for as little as Rs 400, or an external modem for about Rs 1,400. You want more good

news? The necessary software you'll need to set up your computer to be an answering machine or fax comes with the modem—free again.

Software-based answering machines and faxes have other benefits too. For one, a software-based answering machine can have many voice-mailboxes—one for each extension, or employee. A software-based fax saves on paper, as all outgoing and incoming mail is saved on a PC, and only what's required is printed. Let's take a look at the steps involved in setting up a computer to be an answering machine-cum-fax.

First, a small checklist! Make sure you have the following, apart from a computer:

1. A Voice/Data/Fax modem
2. A telephone connection
3. An answering machine software

such as PhoneTools eXpert or SuperVoice

4. A sound card and a microphone with headset or speakers

In this workshop, we will use PhoneTools expert. This software comes with most Voice/Data/Fax modems, or can be downloaded from <http://www.bvrp.com/ENG/products/PhoneToolseXPert>.

Answering machine

Start by installing the software. Double-click on the file to start the installation process. The installation is fairly simple, though you have to keep clicking the 'Next' button several times. Punching in the license information is an important step that shouldn't be overlooked.

The next important step is to enter the Identifier, Telephone Number and Fax Number. The Identifier helps the recipient of the fax to identify the source. It is a 20-character alphanumeric